



66

"MY ENDEAVOUR IS NOT ONLY TO

produce quality products, but also to improve those that are of inferior quality, by investing in better fertilisers and cold-storage facilities."

RAHUL GALA SHAH,
ENTREPRENEUR, 30

Rahul Gala Shah has been studying agricultural practices since he returned to his 100-acre landholding in Umbergoan in Gujarat in 2000, after obtaining a degree in horticulture from the University of Queensland, Australia. "I always wanted to come back and be a farmer," says Shah, who worked with his father for about a year and moved base to Kutch in 2001. His father was the first in Umbergoan to adopt drip irrigation farming in 1983 and established Jalbindu Agritech in 1996.

Shah wanted to put Kutch on the map as a leading producer of dates. His plans hit a roadblock, however, as erratic electricity became a snag. Following his father's footsteps, Shah revolutionised the existing irrigation and fertilisation system by computerising it. Where there are highly advanced systems available at a cost of over Rs 10 lakh, Shah invested less than Rs 1 lakh and within four months, installed a computer and supporting hardware as well as designed a semi-automatic system in 2003. Now he punches in the data, with details of irrigation levels and fertilisation time for each plantation, and the system works automatically once the power returns.

Shah co-founded the Kutch Dates Development Consortium (KDDC) in 2006 with the aim of teaching its member farmers about technology and date farming. The 550-acre plantation owned by the KDDC is expected to reap 6,000 to 8,000 tonnes of dates by 2010-11. This has caught the attention of big farmers and companies like Reliance and Essar as well as the Rajasthan Government. Shah, who has been exporting dates under the brand name Golden Dates, has now begun harvesting figs, pomegranates and grapes. "I started farming on 24 acres of land. Today, my plantations stretch up to 160 acres," says Shah, whose company has an annual turnover of Rs 1.5 crore. **by Purvi Malhotra**

The big Hurdle

Getting people to work in his plantation because of the remoteness of the farmland and limited accessibility.

